national highways amounted to 114,158 kilometres in 2017 while China had 149,600 kilometres in 2018[6]. These figures for rail and road connectivity suggest the two countries are roughly equal – which is a bit of a surprise given the image of China as an infrastructure leader. In fact, given the much larger land area of China, it should have a more extensive set of railways and highways. The figures are not the whole story though. They omit the frequency of trains and how many lanes typically feature on Indian and Chinese highways: clearly, any estimate of the volume of traffic on trains and highways must be multiplied by train frequency and the number of lanes, respectively.

More importantly, the figures say nothing about the quality of rail and road travel and traveller experience. In 2012, I was in Beijing and Shanghai to conduct interviews with Chinese officials, academics, and think tank experts on the state of India–China relations. After a round of interactions in Beijing, I decided to take the Jinghu high-speed railway to Shanghai. The train had begun operations only a few months earlier in 2011, and I was curious. It was also the quickest way to get to my Shanghai hotel, given that the train takes you from downtown Beijing to downtown Shanghai and you avoid the drive to and from suburban airports.

Drawing on memories of Indian railway journeys, I expected a noisome building and heaving/shoving fellow passengers as we boarded the train. Instead, the station was like an international airport – high-domed, all chrome and crystalline, serviced by smartly attired personnel, and easy to navigate all the way to the compartment. I had paid to travel executive class, which I innocently expected might be equivalent to the highest class on the Indian Shatabdi trains. In fact, I stepped into an interior that resembled business-class air travel and was shown to my seat by an elegant steward. The journey of 1300 kilometres took roughly four hours – the Beijing–Shanghai high-speed train is widely acknowledged to be the fastest intercity train in the world. The countryside flew by my window, with a gentle thrumming and swaying against air resistance. Leaning back, I thought of my train rides from Delhi to Mumbai: the same distance, covered